covered Rahman's message intensely. Blaming the US and its coalition partners for 'butchering Muslims', Rahman threatened eternal war in Afghanistan unless the Taliban were taken into the government.[70] Allegedly, an independent Indian MP, Lalit Suri, who was close to Uttar Pradesh' (UP) Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Mulayam Singh Yadav, had bankrolled Rahman's visit. It was a politically audacious event that angered the US for whom Rahman was 'a wolf in wolf's clothing' entertained by an Indian 'rogue's gallery'. Washington saw the visit as an anti-US and anti-UPA conspiracy hatched by the 'witches' brew' of the JuH, the Samajwadi Party, and other pro-Iran Muslim clerics in India. But then came the shocker. On 19 May 2006 Rahman was invited for a meeting with the PM. While the details of what transpired in the meeting are not known, the fact that such a meeting took place underlines PM Manmohan Singh's conciliatory credentials.

Baptising India's conciliatory approach towards the Taliban, Manmohan Singh had set the ball rolling for India to deepen engagement with all political entities in Afghanistan and Pakistan, irrespective of the militancy of their Islam and closeness with Pakistan's security agencies. By 2008 New Delhi had developed connectivity with a host of Afghan insurgents ranging from Hekmatyar to various Taliban figures linked to the Quetta shura. This shift in stance, in addition to a slow policy learning process and the kidnapping of Indian citizens, was to do with the shock of Karzai's open offer to Mullah Omar and Hekmatyar to enter talks and join the government in October 2007.[71] With the 2009 national elections in sight, Karzai had domestic political reasons to launch such public initiatives. The declaration came as a rude surprise to the US as well as India. Narayanan, a partisan who had invested tremendous political capital in Karzai, was caught in an awkward situation where his own PM was pushing for regional reconciliation and the Afghan president was openly talking to the Taliban.

Narayanan, of course, knew about these covert links between Indian and Afghan intelligence officials and the Taliban. He considered intelligence links with the Taliban necessary and thought that they did not represent government policy. But in light of India's nonexistent intelligence links with the Taliban in the 1990s, this was a marked operational departure. Narayanan never saw such contacts as an exercise in seeking a rapprochement. Though the MEA was